

Yahoo! Goes OpenID

Internet giant Yahoo! Recently announced that it would now be possible to use Yahoo! user IDs on Web sites that support the OpenID system, a decentralised sign-on system that authenticates a user based on a URL assigned to that user by an OpenID provider.



Netscape Navigator Retires

The most popular browser during much of the 1990s—Netscape Navigator—has retired, with parent company AOL announcing that it would stop security updates and technical support beginning this month. It will, however, allow nostalgic users to download archived versions.



Enter



Ajai Chowdhry
Founder, Chairman and CEO,
HCL Infosystems Ltd

HCL Infosystems Ltd, the pioneers behind India's first microcomputer, first Desktop PC and first home PC, recently launched a range of ultra-portable laptops: the MiLeap X & Y series. We had a quick round of questions with Ajai Chowdhry, Founder of HCL and Chairman and CEO of HCL Infosystems Ltd.

How different are computing habits and environments in India from those in the rest of the world?

Not very different. The external physical environment, however, in which Indians operate is very different; laptops here are subjected to a lot of dust, pollution, and climatic extremes. The MiLeap series is very rugged and designed to sustain normal wear and tear; the MiLeap model in the X-Series comes with a leather casing, giving it the appearance of a leather-bound diary.

What usage scenarios and application areas do you plan to target with future products in this category?

The ultraportable form factor, full functionality, and the fiercely competitive price are the USPs of the MiLeap range. The convenience factor has opened up limitless possibilities in new usage scenarios.

Having introducing the MiLeap series, do you believe that the near future of personal computing in India is ultra-portable?

Targeted at consumers who need to stay connected, informed, entertained, and productive anytime and anywhere, these laptops' weight and size makes it so convenient that a user need not think twice about carrying it to the office, home, gym, or park, or using it in a train, bus, plane, or metro. This revolution in personal computing in India will be sustained by four critical factors: price, size, features, and most importantly, availability of high-speed broadband.

HUMANS FOR HUMANITY

Helping, The SN Way

Here's more reason to take the social networking phenomenon seriously. Google.org's executive director Dr Larry Brilliant is running a project called Innovative Support to Emergencies, Diseases and Disaster (InSTEDD; talk about silly-sounding acronyms), which will leverage the use of existing social networking technologies like Facebook Mini-Feeds and Twitter updates to reach out to individuals in distress.

Here's how it works. As a patient, you can text-message the InSTEDD number asking for help. InSTEDD volunteers, who can locate your exact position via Google Earth, receive this message. Once your position is located, they search for UN or other humanitarian aid volunteers in the region and forward your query to them. The volunteers reply to you with a description of what medicines you should take, or with their address. Once the conversation is complete, software automatically links your mobile number with the group that last assisted you, so that when you send a message next time, it

directly reaches the volunteer group closest to you. If you send a text message from a different location, the software will detect the change and the process will repeat.



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

As a patient, you also have the option of subscribing to updates from the closest volunteer group in your area. This helps spread warning messages quickly to a large number of people. There is talk of improving response time by having volunteers from all around the world subscribe to GeoRSS feeds (feeds delivered to users based on the geographical location of their contact

number). The software can send out these feeds based on the geographical location of the patient and of the volunteer.

Since the project works using existing free technologies and software like Google Earth, Live Maps, Geo-coding Web services, and applications built on ASP.NET, they can be built and deployed quickly and inexpensively over a large, populous area. Twitter is being used as the worldwide SMS gateway, while Facebook is being used to geo-tag incoming requests with its Mini-Feed feature, and send out requests for help to volunteers in the region.

Brilliant is also considering the expansion of a Web crawler (software that indexes information from Web pages) used by the Canadian Government called the Global Public Health Intelligence Network. This will monitor 20,000 Web sites in seven languages, which could search for keywords used on Web pages from a specific location, and based on the time difference between these, can actually warn of a possible outbreak of either a disease or an act of terrorism to volunteers in the area!

Security Watch

Excel Under Attack

The Problem

A vulnerability—rated as “Extremely Critical” by security firm Secunia—has been reported in Microsoft Excel. As you'd expect, it can be exploited by Men With Malicious Minds to compromise a system.

It has something to do with how Excel handles files, but what exactly it is has not yet been specified. The vulnerability can be exploited if an attacker uses a specially-crafted Excel file with malformed header information.

Successful exploitation, as you've come to expect by now when something is rated Highly Critical, allows execution of arbitrary code on the victim's computer. According to Microsoft, this is currently being actively exploited.

The Solution

There isn't any—at least, there wasn't at the time of writing. If you get an e-mail with an Excel attachment, don't open the attachment unless you've spoken with the sender beforehand, or unless you're expecting it. Check <http://tinyurl.com/yotn2k> when you read this to see if a patch has been released.

The project has solid backing, with Google alone having invested \$5 million (Rs 20 crore). It has also received investments from the Rockefeller Foundation for \$1 million (Rs 4 crore) and is expected to receive another six-figure investment from John Doerr, a well-known venture capitalist.

COME SP3...

Microsoft Drops Support—Again

With the arrival of Service Pack 3 (SP3) for Office 2003, Microsoft has decided to stop support for older file formats—Word 4.x and below for Windows and 5.x for Mac. What this means is that if your company has any Office document backups from before 1992, they will not be readable with this update. Apart from that, this update also removes compatibility for older spreadsheet products that compete with

Microsoft's—like Corel Draw, Lotus, and Quattro.

Microsoft claims to have dropped support due to the formats being “less secure” than the current-generation Office 2003 and 2007 formats. Though this may be true, many users are one again pointing fingers at Microsoft for being the bully and forcing newer products on them. As companies and individuals alike back up more and more data, Microsoft's planned obsolescence of older file formats is worrying. Not only that, SP3 is reportedly riddled with bugs, with many users reporting frequent crashes and instability of Office after the upgrade. Even a complete re-install of the program does not seem to solve the problem.

The company does offer workarounds to fix the problem, and in an effort to wave the olive flag, has described two ways of doing so. One method involves downloading the Office 2003 Service Pack 3 Administrative Template and set templates for users across a domain—something not for the end user. Another method involves editing Registry

HOT

WiMax

The broadband technology that will connect us all. We've witnessed WiMax trials throughout 2007, even getting Internet access out in the middle of the sea! And now, Reliance has even started providing WiMax Internet in some parts of the country...

NOT

It Sucks!

...well, the service does, to be fair. In a Google search for “reliance wimax”, the first result is a Web page that tells you loudly, “Reliance Wi-max services—don't go for it!” Sounds like the broadband bitching is never going to end for us...

What are your views on electronic publications?

(You, too, can participate in this poll—at www.thinkdigit.com)

A You just can't beat the feel of paper

C I'd rather read the electronic version than not read at all

B I only read small articles online; it's still print for me

D Dump paper! Save the trees! Make *Digit* an e-mag!

I'd choose B. The current e-publication methods are not conducive to sustain reading them over an extended period of time. It is possible to read them if the articles are short and concise. Nothing beats the convenience of reading a book on your couch.

Shubhankar Dattagupta
Pune



I've chosen B because I'm introduced to topics or articles at the computer, so I don't mind reading small articles on the monitor. But it strains the eyes more. Hence nothing beats paper for me.

Antonio Anastasio Bruto da Costa
Margao, Goa



I'll take C; I do prefer reading a book, but I like to have e-books for them as well. It's the best way to save the books as well as space.

Naveed Patel
Pune



I'll go with option B. Small articles may be read in e-media, but it's painful to read a whole magazine like *Digit* and its *Fast Track* in electronic media. Don't convert the magazine into an e-mag!

Sujit Kumar Ghosh
Digboi (Assam)



I vote for option A. Electronic reading puts a stress on the eyes. I have tried reading e-books of my engineering-related e-books... but I never completed them—I had to buy printed books for those topics.

Ravi Shekhar
Delhi



Reading magazines on a computer is definitely not tiring. E-mags have some nice, useful features like Web links and search features, which you can't get with a paper magazine. So I choose D.

Millind Alvares
Goa Parra



(You, too, can participate in this poll—at www.thinkdigit.com)